WEB BASICS

CMS

Content management systems: how websites let people publish and manage content without writing code.



THE BASICS

What is a CMS?

A content management system (CMS) is software that lets people create, edit and publish website content without writing code.

Editors work in a simple admin area. The CMS stores the content and turns it into web pages.

Create
Write pages and posts.

Manage
Edit, organize and review.

Publish
Put it live with one click.

THE BASICS

Why websites use a CMS

WITHOUT A CMS

- Every change means editing code
- Only developers can publish
- Pages drift apart in style
- Hard to see who changed what

WITH A CMS

- Editors publish on their own
- One design for every page
- Content is saved and versioned
- Roles control who can do what

A CMS keeps content (words, images) apart from design (layout, style). You can change one without touching the other.

HOW IT WORKS

The main parts of a CMS

1 Admin area
Where editors write and manage content.

→

2 Database
Stores text, settings and file records.

→

3 Templates
Define layout and style for each page type.

→

4 Web server
Builds the page and sends it to visitors.

Two sides work together: the admin side, where content is managed, and the public side, where pages are delivered.

FEATURES

What a CMS usually gives you

Visual editor

Write and format like a document.

Media library

Upload and reuse images and files.

Users and roles

Control who can edit or publish.

Templates

Change the design in one place.

Revisions

Go back to an earlier version.

Plugins

Add features without custom code.

SEO tools

Set titles, descriptions and URLs.

Scheduling

Publish at a set date and time.

HOW IT WORKS

What happens when someone visits a page

1 Request

A visitor opens a URL in the browser.

2 Route

The server passes the request to the CMS.

3 Fetch

The CMS reads the content from the database.

4 Build

It fills a template with that content.

5 Respond

The server sends back the finished HTML.

6 Display

The browser shows the page to the visitor.

Many CMSs save the finished page (a cache) so the next visit is faster.

TYPES OF CMS

Three kinds of CMS

TRADITIONAL

Content and pages live in one system. The CMS builds the site that visitors see.

EXAMPLES

WordPress, Drupal, October CMS

HEADLESS

The CMS only stores content. Apps get it through an API and show it any way they like.

EXAMPLES

Strapi, Contentful, Sanity

HYBRID

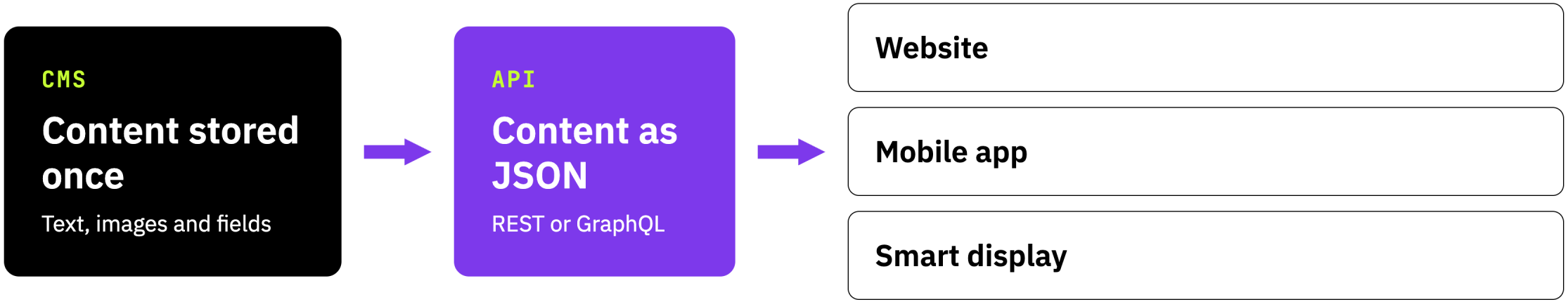
Works as a traditional CMS and also offers an API for other apps.

EXAMPLES

Drupal, WordPress with its REST API

TYPES OF CMS

How a headless CMS works



Write the content once and show it anywhere. The front end is built separately with any tool, such as React or Expo.

TYPES OF CMS

Traditional or headless?

Feature	Traditional	Headless
Front end	Built in, with themes	You build it
Delivery	Finished web pages	Content through an API
Setup speed	Fast	Slower
Flexibility	Limited by the theme	Very high
Skills needed	Low to medium	Developers
Best for	Blogs and business sites	Apps and many channels

EXAMPLES

Popular CMS tools

Name	Type	Good for
WordPress	Traditional	Blogs and business sites
Drupal	Traditional, hybrid	Large, complex sites
October CMS	Traditional	Developer-friendly sites (Laravel)
Strapi	Headless	Custom APIs, open source
Contentful	Headless	Hosted content for many apps
Ghost	Traditional	Publishing and newsletters

MANAGING PEOPLE

Users and roles

Role	What they can do
Administrator	Everything: settings, users, plugins, content
Editor	Edit and publish all content
Author	Write and publish their own content
Contributor	Write drafts, but not publish

Role names vary by CMS. Give each person the lowest role that lets them do the job. This is called least privilege.

MANAGING CONTENT

The life of a piece of content

1 Draft

An author writes the content. Only the team can see it.

2 Review

An editor checks facts, tone and spelling.

3 Approve

A manager signs it off, if the team needs this step.

4 Publish

The content goes live now or at a set time.

5 Update

Changes are saved as new revisions.

6 Archive

Old content is hidden but not deleted.

A CMS tracks the status at each step, so nobody publishes by mistake.

How to choose a CMS

Ask	Why it matters
Who edits?	Non-technical editors need a simple admin area.
What are you building?	A blog, a store, an app, or content for many channels.
Team skills?	PHP, JavaScript, or no code at all.
Total cost?	Hosting, licenses, plugins and support.
Security?	Look for regular updates and an active community.
Growth?	Check speed, caching and multi-site support.

KEEPING IT SAFE

Keep your CMS secure

Risk	What to do
Outdated core or plugins	Update often and remove what you do not use
Weak or reused passwords	Use strong passwords and two-factor login
Too many admins	Give the lowest role that works
Lost data	Back up the files and database on a schedule
Unsafe traffic	Use HTTPS everywhere

Many CMS attacks target outdated plugins and themes.

GETTING STARTED

Launching a site on a CMS

1 Pick

Choose a CMS that fits your site and team.

2 Host

Set up hosting or a managed platform.

3 Install

Install the CMS and create your admin login.

4 Design

Choose a theme or build your own templates.

5 Add content

Create pages, posts and menus.

6 Launch

Connect your domain, turn on HTTPS and go live.

After launch: update the CMS, back up, and review user roles regularly.

SUMMARY

Key points

1. A CMS lets people publish without writing code.
2. Content lives in a database; templates build the pages.
3. Traditional CMSs build the site. Headless ones serve an API.
4. Roles, revisions and workflow keep content safe.
5. Choose by team skills, site type, cost and security.